Bangladesh 2019

Gender Equality

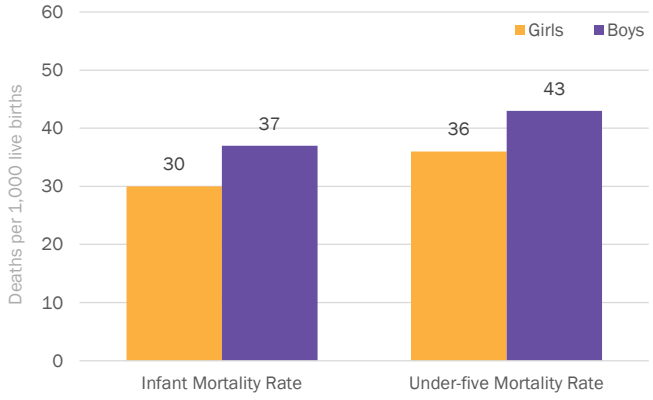
Multiple Indicator Cluster Surveys

Gender equality means that girls and boys, women and men, enjoy the same rights, resources, opportunities and protections. Investments in gender equality contribute to lifelong positive outcomes for children and their communities and have considerable inter-generational payoffs because children's rights and well-being often depend on women's rights and well-being. This snapshot shows key dimensions of gender equality during the lifecycle. It is organized around: 1) the first decade of life (0-9 years of age) when gender disparities are often small, particularly in early childhood; 2) the second decade of childhood (10-19 years of age) when gender disparities become more pronounced with the onset of puberty and the consolidation of gender norms; and 3) adulthood, when gender disparities impacts both the wellbeing of women and girls and boys.

Every Girl & Boy Survives & Thrives: The First Decade of Life

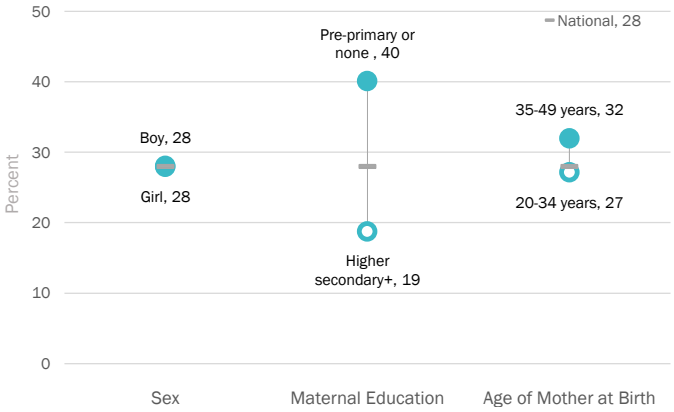
Nutrition and a supportive environment in early childhood are among the key determinants of the health and survival of children and their physical and cognitive development. Generally, girls tend to have better biological endowments than boys for survival to age five, and thus higher survival chances under natural circumstances. However, gender discrimination against girls can affect survival, resulting in higher than expected female mortality. Similarly, stunting rates are typically lower among girls than boys, potentially due to the higher risk for preterm birth among boys, which is inextricably linked with lower birth weight. However, children with mothers who gave birth at a young age or who have no education may be more likely to be malnourished. Children with restricted cognitive development during early life are at risk for later neuropsychological problems, poor school achievement, early school drop-out, low-skilled employment, and poor care of their own children. Stimulation and interaction with parents and caregivers can jumpstart brain development and promote well-being in early childhood. This is also the period of development when gender socialization, or the process of learning cultural roles according to one's sex, manifests. Caregivers, particularly fathers, may respond to, and interact with, sons and daughters differently.

Mortality Rates among Children Under-5, SDG 3.2.1 Sex Disaggregate



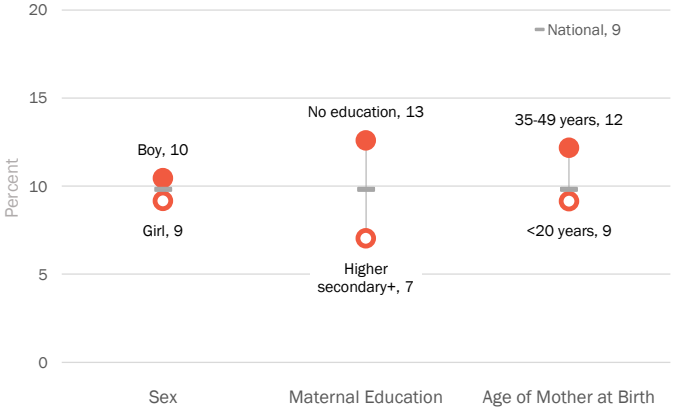
Infant mortality: probability of dying between birth and the first birthday
Under-five mortality: the probability of dying between birth and the fifth birthday

Malnutrition: Stunting (Moderate & Severe) among Children Under-5, SDG 2.2.1 (lowest vs highest)



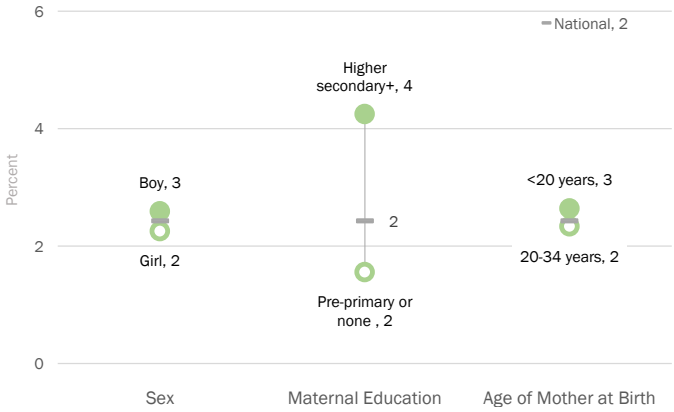
Stunting refers to a child too short for his or her age

Malnutrition: Wasting (Moderate & Severe) among Children Under-5, SDG 2.2.2 (lowest vs highest)



Wasting refers to a child who is too thin for his or her height

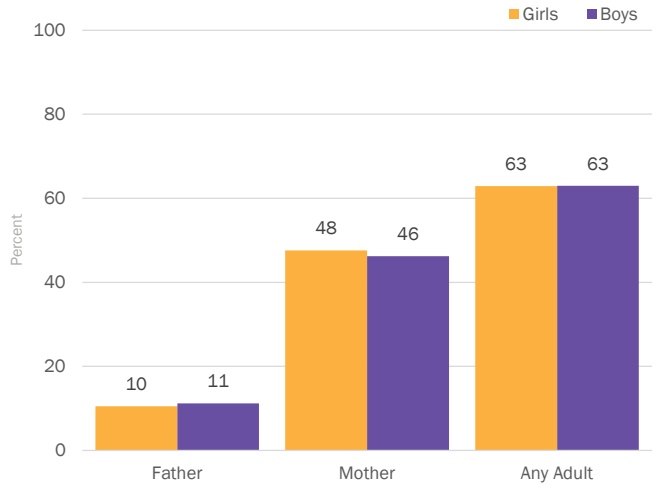
Malnutrition: Overweight (Moderate & Severe) among Children Under-5, SDG 2.2.2 (lowest vs highest)



Overweight refers to a child who is too heavy for his or her height

Every Girl & Boy Survives & Thrives: The First Decade of Life

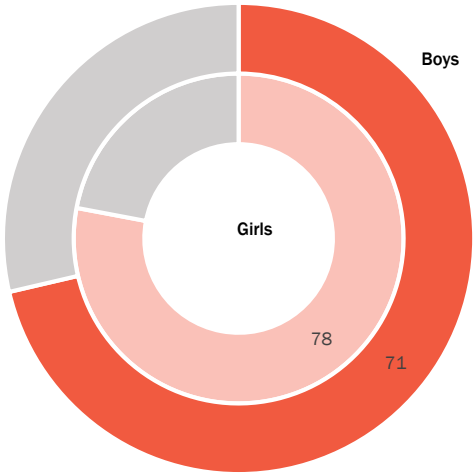
Early Stimulation & Responsive Care by Adults



Percentage of children age 2-4 years with whom adult household members engaged in activities that promote learning and school readiness during the last three days, by person interacting with child and sex of child.

Note: Activities include: reading books to the child; telling stories to the child; singing songs to the child; taking the child outside the home; playing with the child; and naming, counting or drawing things with the child

Early Childhood Development Index, SDG 4.2.1

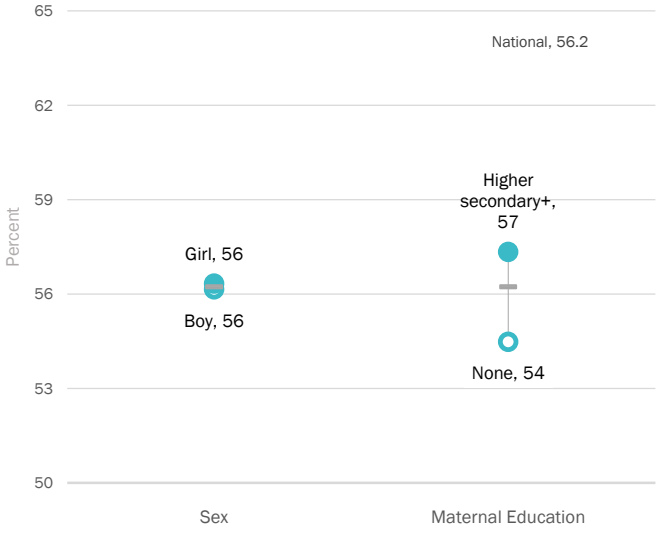


Percentage of children age 3-4 years who are developmentally on track in at least 3 of the following 4 domains: literacy-numeracy, physical, social-emotional, and learning domains, by sex

Every Girl & Boy Is Protected From Violence & Exploitation: The First Decade of Life

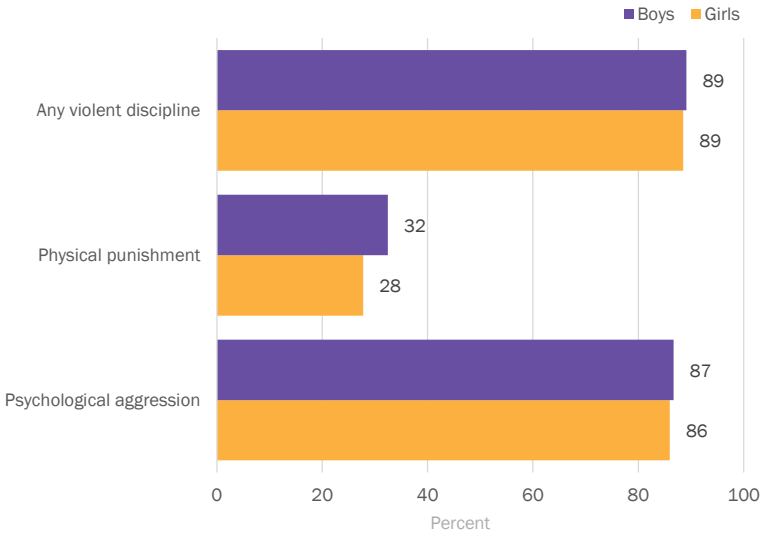
Registering children at birth is the first step in securing their recognition before the law, safeguarding their rights, and ensuring that any violation of these rights does not go unnoticed. While vitally important for both girls and boys, the implications of low birth registration rates for girls are significant, rendering them more vulnerable to certain forms of exploitation they are at greater risk of, including child marriage and international trafficking. Although average birth registration rates are similar for girls and boys, children with mothers who have no education may be less likely to have their births registered. While girls and boys face similar risks of experiencing violent discipline -which includes physical punishment and psychological aggression- by caregivers in the home, gender inequality and domestic violence are among the factors associated with an elevated risk of violence against both girls and boys.

Birth Registration, SDG 16.9.1 Sex Disaggregate



Percentage of children under age 5 whose births are registered, by sex and maternal education level

Violent Discipline, SDG 16.2.1 Sex Disaggregate

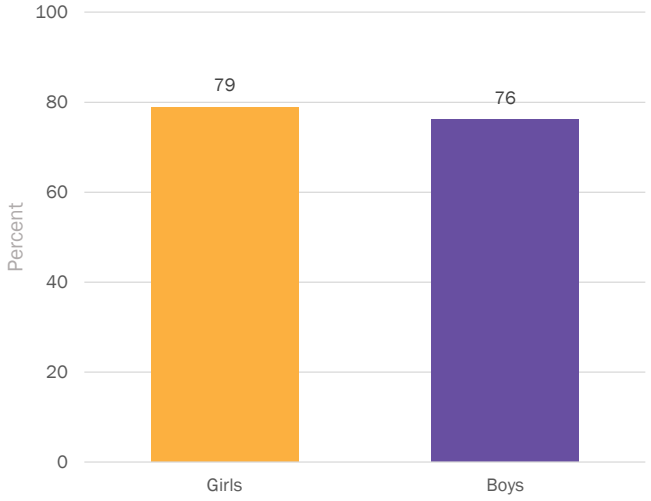


Percentage of children age 1-14 years who experienced violent discipline in the past month, by sex
Note: The age group 1-14 spans the first and second decades of life.

Every Girl & Boy Learns: The First Decade of Life

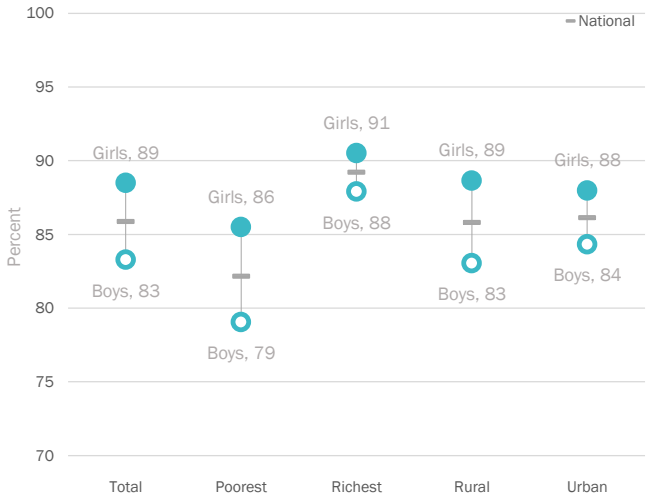
Investment in good quality early childhood education services prior to entering school improves learning outcomes for children. It also enhances the efficiency of the school system by reducing repetition and drop-out and improving achievement, especially among girls and marginalized groups. Primary education provides the foundation for a lifetime of learning. Considerable progress has been made in achieving universal education and closing the gender gap but gender disparities to the disadvantage of girls still exist in some countries. Further, girls still comprise the majority of the world's out-of-school population.
Note: Because children of primary school age range from 6-14 years, these indicators include some children in their second decade of life.

Participation Rate in Organized Learning, SDG 4.2.2



Percent distribution of children age one year younger than the official primary school entry age at the beginning of the school year, by attendance to education, and attendance to an early childhood education programme or primary education (adjusted net attendance ratio), by sex

Primary School Attendance

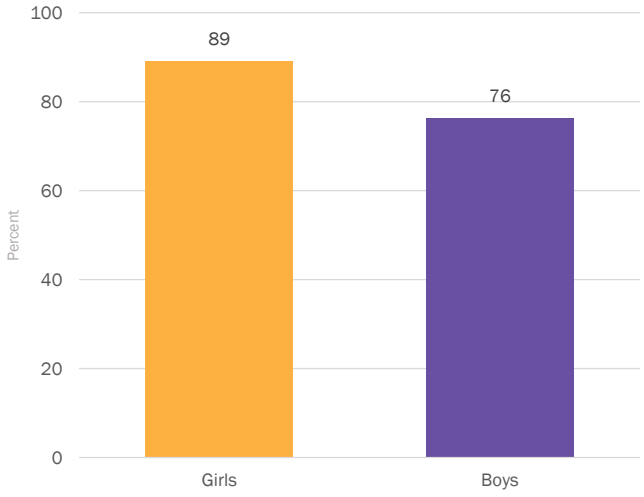


Percentage of children of primary school age attending primary or secondary school (adjusted net attendance ratio), by wealth quintile and urban/rural residence

Children of Primary School Age Out of School

Percentage of children of primary school age not attending either primary or secondary school, by wealth quintile and area

Primary Completion



Percentage of children who age 3 to 5 years above the intended age for the last grade of primary school who have completed primary education, by sex

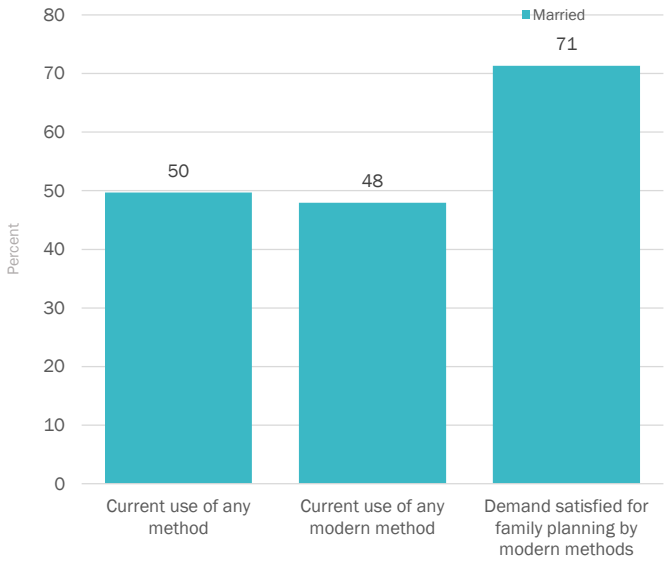
Key Messages

- In the first decade of life (0-9 years of age) gender disparities – the right of males and females to enjoy the same rights, resources, opportunities and protections – are often small, particularly in early childhood. But during the second decade of childhood (10-19 years of age) gender disparities become more pronounced, especially with the onset of puberty and the consolidation of gender norms. During adulthood, gender disparities seriously affect the wellbeing of women, girls and boys.
- In Bangladesh, the infant and child mortality rate is higher for boys than for girls. These data align with what is observed for child survival in many countries under natural circumstances.
- In Bangladesh, many indicators related to development of children show low or little disparities between boys and girls. However, boys are less likely than girls to participate in organized learning and they are less likely to attend primary school. Boys are also less likely to complete primary school (76%) than are girls (89%). These data show promising improvement for girls over the years. However, more work needs to be done to understand why boys are now lagging behind girls for participation in and completion of primary school.

Every Adolescent Girl & Boy Survives & Thrives: The Second Decade of Life

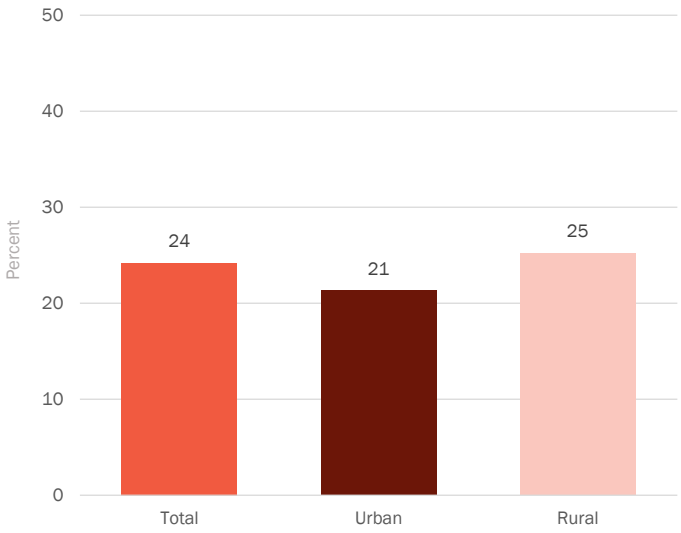
While adolescence carries new health risks for both girls and boys, girls often face gender-specific vulnerabilities, with lifelong consequences. Complications related to pregnancy and childbirth are among the leading causes of death worldwide for adolescent girls age 15 to 19. Preventing adolescent pregnancy not only improves the health of adolescent girls, but also provides them with opportunities to continue their education, preparing them for jobs and livelihoods, increasing their self-esteem and giving them more say in decisions that affect their lives. Yet, too often, adolescent girls lack access to appropriate sexual and reproductive health services, including modern methods of contraception. Additionally, despite having a higher risk of contracting HIV due to both greater physiological vulnerabilities and gender inequalities, adolescent girls are often less knowledgeable than adolescent boys about how HIV is transmitted. However, gender norms adversely impact adolescent boys as well. For example, norms around masculinity that encourage risk taking may heighten adolescent boys' use of alcohol and tobacco, increasing their likelihood of developing noncommunicable diseases later in life.

Contraceptive Use & Demand Satisfied



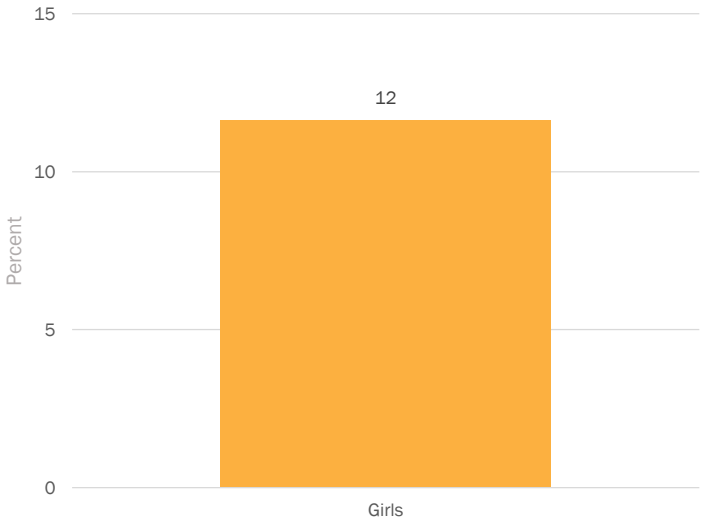
Contraceptive use and demand for family planning satisfied by modern methods among adolescent girls age 15-19, by marital status

Early Childbearing - by Age 18



Percentage of women age 20-24 years who had a live birth by age 18, by urban/rural residence

Comprehensive Knowledge of HIV

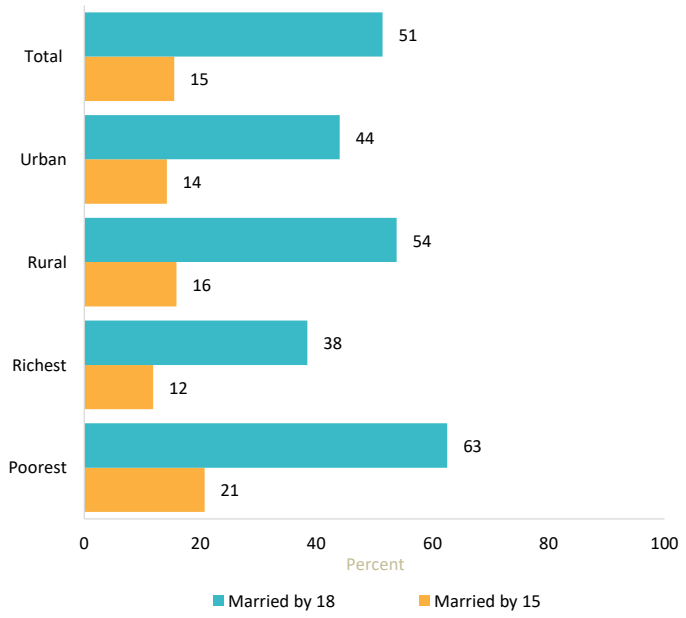


Percent of girls age 15-24 who know of the two ways of HIV prevention (having only one faithful uninfected partner and using a condom every time), who know that a healthy looking person can be HIV-positive, and who reject the two most common misconceptions, and any other local misconception.

Every Adolescent Girl & Boy is Protected from Violence & Exploitation: The Second Decade of Life

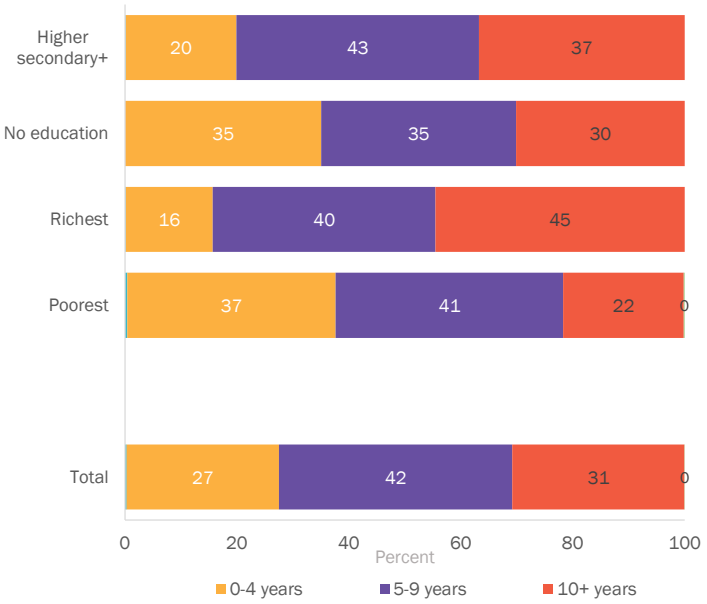
Adolescence presents unique vulnerabilities to violence and exploitation for girls. In many countries, marriage before the age of 18 is a reality for girls due to the interaction of several factors that place a girl at risk, including poverty, social norms, customary or religious laws that condone the practice, an inadequate legislative framework and the state of a country's civil registration system. Child marriage often compromises a girl's development by resulting in early pregnancy and social isolation, interrupting her schooling, and limiting her opportunities for career and vocational advancement. It also often involves a substantial age difference between the girl and her partner, thus further disempowering her and putting her at greater risk of partner violence, sexually transmitted diseases and lack of agency. Attitudes about wife beating serve as a marker for the social acceptability of intimate partner violence. Acceptance of wife beating among adolescent girls and boys suggests that it can be difficult for married girls who experience violence to seek assistance and for unmarried girls to identify and negotiate healthy and equitable relationships. Gender-based discrimination may be one of the most ubiquitous forms of discrimination adolescent girls face, and it has long-lasting and far-reaching effects on their personal trajectories as well as on all aspects of social and economic development. While in most regions, girls and boys are equally likely to be involved in child labour, gender is a determinant of the types of activities boys and girls engage in, with girls more likely to be involved in domestic work.

Child Marriage, SDG 5.3.1



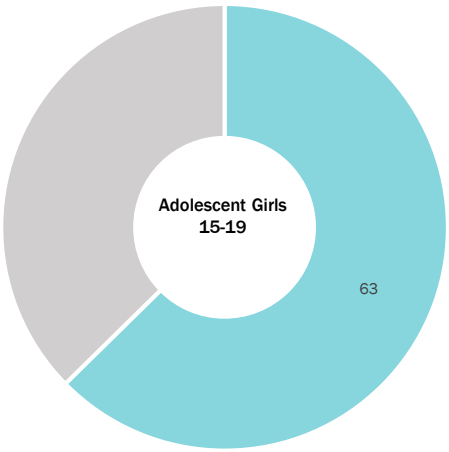
Percentage of women aged 20-24 years who were first married before age 15 and before age 18*, by residence

Spousal Age Difference



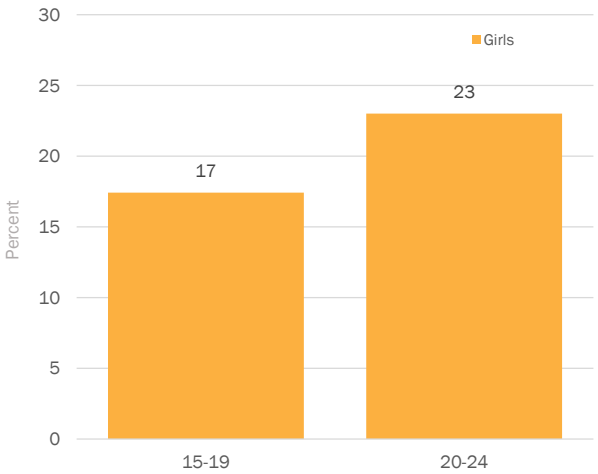
Percent distribution of adolescent girls age 15-19 currently married age difference with their partner, education level and wealth quintile

Feelings of Safety, SDG 16.1.4 Age & women Disaggregate



Percentage of adolescent girls age 15-19 who feel safe walking alone in their neighborhood after dark

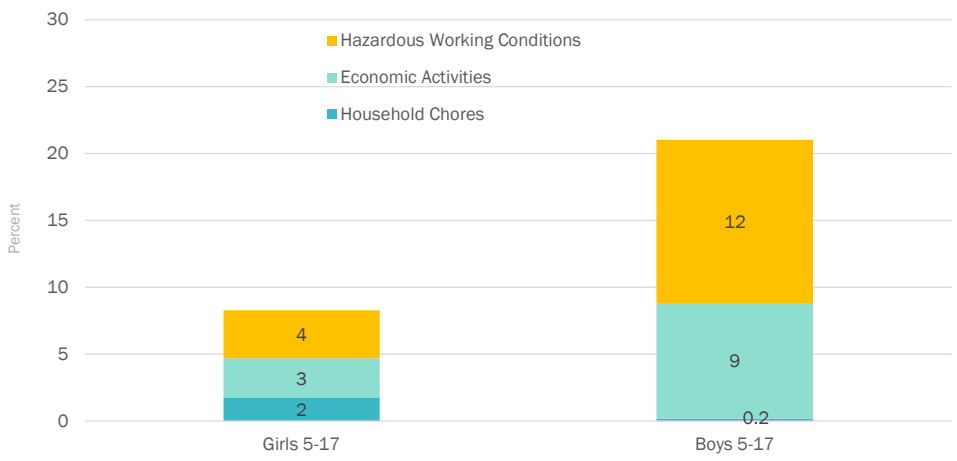
Attitudes toward Domestic Violence



Percentage of adolescents age 15-49 years who justify wife beating for any of the following reasons: she goes out without telling him; she neglects the children; she argues with him; she refuses sex with him; she burns the food, by sex and age group

Every Adolescent Girl & Boy is Protected from Violence & Exploitation: The Second Decade of Life

Child Labour & Hazardous Working Conditions



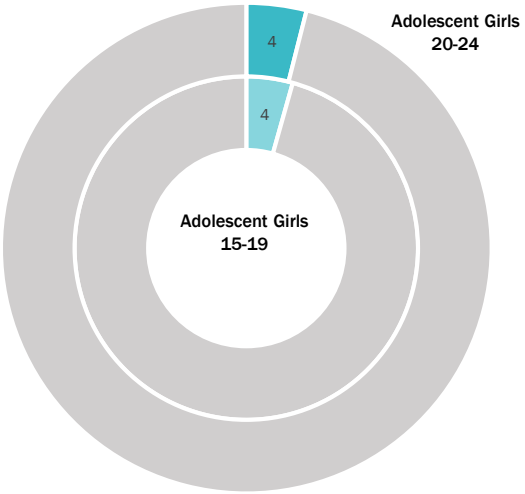
Percentage of children age 5 to 17 years engaged in child labour, by sex, age group and type of activity

Note: Indicator includes children in the first & second decade of life

Every Adolescent Girl & Boy has an Equitable Chance in Life: The Second Decade of Life

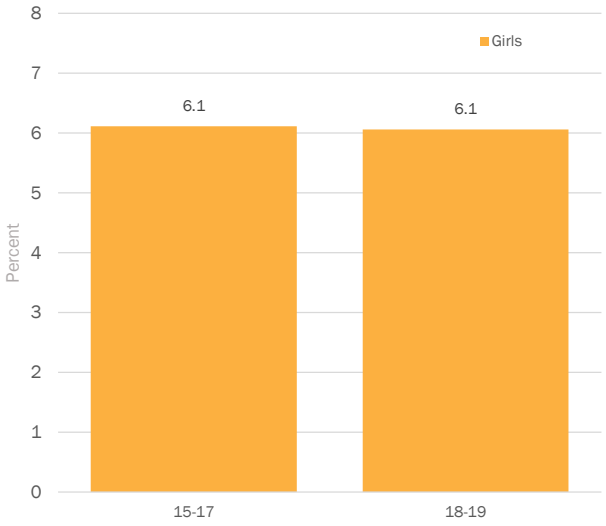
To become empowered, adolescent girls and boys need to be engaged as civic participants in the decisions affecting their lives and communities. People's sense of security and freedom from the fear of crime influences how they move about those communities, access services and economic opportunities and participate in public life. Adolescent girls and boys are likely to have different perceptions of personal safety due to different gender-based vulnerabilities to sexual violence and other crimes. Life satisfaction measures an individual's perceived level of well-being or how an individual feels about their life as a whole. Measuring adolescent girls' and boy's satisfaction with their lives can provide important insights into their mental health during a stage of life when gender norms consolidate and girls and boys experience different risk factors for mental health disorders.

Discrimination & Harassment



Percentage of adolescent girls age 15-49 years who in the last 12 months have felt discriminated or harassed based on their gender

Life Satisfaction

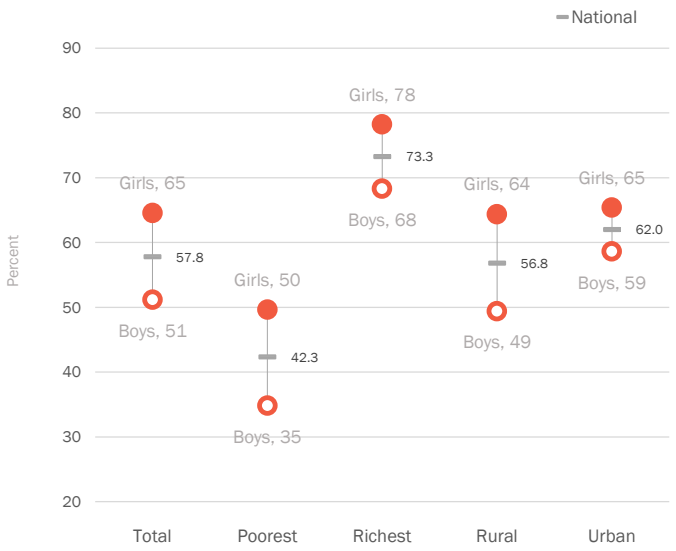


Among adolescent girls age 15-19, average life satisfaction score on a scale of 0 to 10, by sex and age group

Every Adolescent Girl & Boy Learns: The Second Decade of Life

While participation in secondary education is expanding, progress lags behind primary education. Gender disparities disadvantaging girls are also wider and occur in more countries at the secondary level than at the primary level. Yet, advancing girls' secondary education is one of the most transformative development strategies countries can invest in. Completion of secondary education brings significant positive benefits to girls and societies – from increased lifetime earnings and national growth rates, to reductions in child marriage, stunting, and child and maternal mortality.

Lower Secondary Attendance Net Attendance Rate

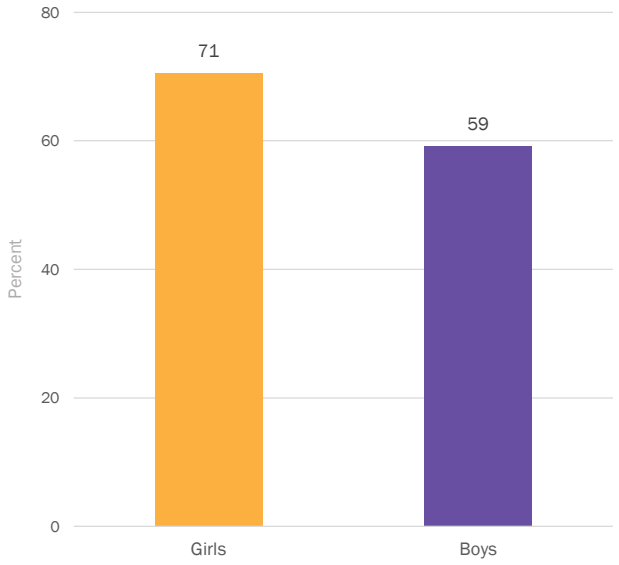


Percentage of children of lower secondary school age attending lower secondary school or higher (adjusted net attendance ratio), by sex, wealth quintile and area

Upper Secondary Attendance Net Attendance Rate

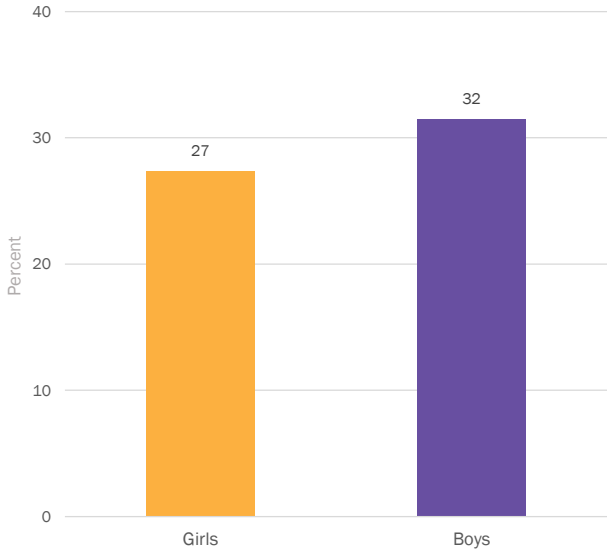
Percentage of children of upper secondary school age attending upper secondary school or higher (adjusted net attendance ratio), by sex, wealth quintile and area

Lower Secondary Completion



Percentage of children who age 3 to 5 years above the intended age for the last grade of lower secondary school who have completed lower secondary education, by sex

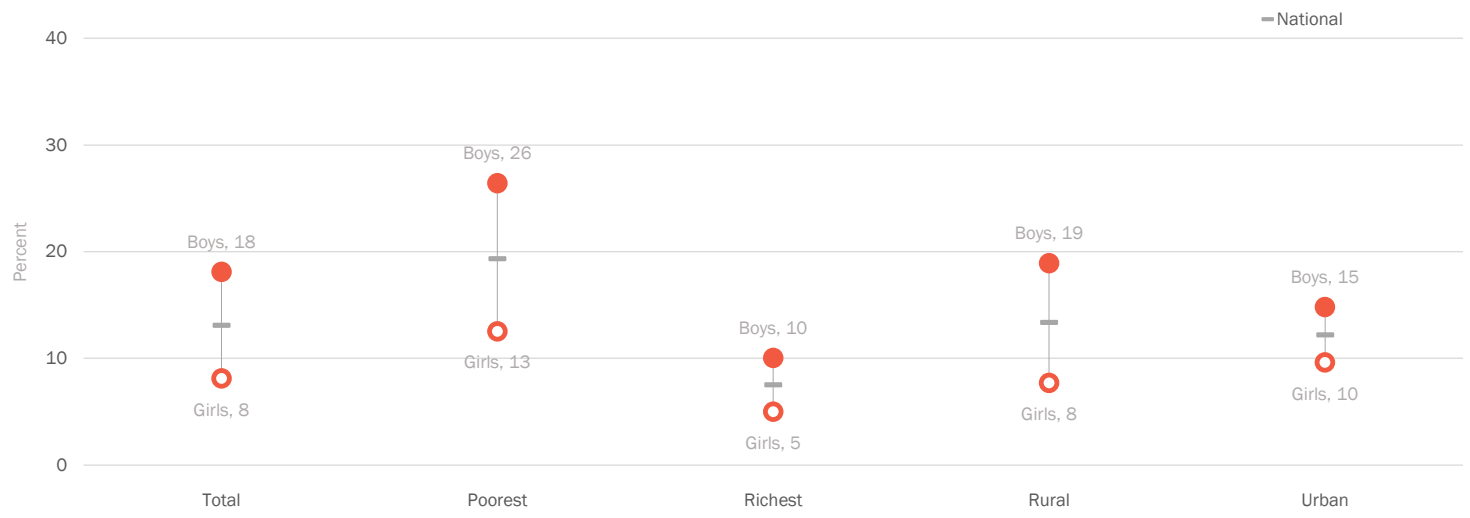
Upper Secondary Completion



Percentage of children or youth who age 3 to 5 years above the intended age for the last grade of upper secondary school who have completed upper secondary education, by sex

Every Adolescent Girl & Boy Learns: The Second Decade of Life

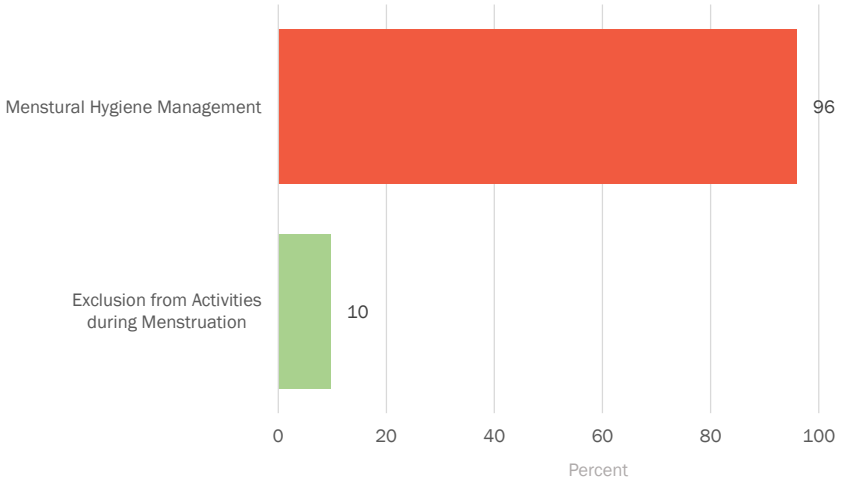
Children of Lower Secondary School Age Out of School



Percentage of children of lower secondary age not attending either primary or secondary school, by wealth quintile and area

Every Adolescent Girl & Boy Lives in a Safe & Clean Environment: The Second Decade of Life

Menstrual Hygiene Management



The ability of adolescent girls to safely manage their monthly menstrual cycle in privacy and with dignity is fundamental to their health, psychosocial well-being and mobility. Girls in low-resource and emergency contexts without access to adequate menstrual hygiene management facilities and supplies experience stigma and social exclusion while also forgoing important educational, social and economic opportunities.

Menstrual Hygiene Management: Among adolescent girls age 15-19 who reported menstruating in the last 12 months, percentage using appropriate menstrual hygiene materials with a private place to wash and change while at home

Exclusion from Activities during Menstruation: Among adolescent girls age 15-19 who reported menstruating in the last 12 months, percentage of women who did not participate in social activities, school or work due to their last menstruation in the last 12 months

Key Messages

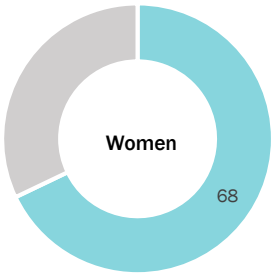
- Child marriage has implications on all aspects of a girl's life during her lifecycle. Child marriage is common in Bangladesh, as is early childbearing. More than half of women age 20-24 years married before they reached their 18th birthday. Women from the poorest households were most likely (63%) to be married before their 18th birthday. Almost one quarter (24%) of married women in Bangladesh had their first birth before their 18th birthday.
- Equipping girls with skills and information, increasing their access to resources, building their agency, and shifting broader social norms related to child marriage and gender equality are central.
- Almost half of the married girls 15-19 years currently use any modern method of contraception, and 71% have their need for family planning satisfied by modern methods of contraception. While these data are promising, almost 31% of married young women in Bangladesh report not having access to modern contraceptives to satisfy their needs for family planning. More work needs to done to provide these young women with access to the modern contraceptives they want.
- In Bangladesh, boys are nearly twice as likely to be engaged in child labour than are girls; they are also less likely to attend lower or upper secondary school. While girls are more likely to complete lower secondary school (71% for girls compared to 59% for boys), boys who attend secondary school are more likely to complete (32%) than are girls (27%). More work is needed to understand the social processes that engage boys in labour early in life and keeps them out of school. While participation in lower and upper secondary school has improved for girls, more work is needed to ensure that both boys and girls attend and complete secondary school.
- Most girls age 15-19 years (96%) were able to manage their menstrual cycle; 10% reported they excluded from activities during their recent menstruation.

Gender Equality in Adulthood

To survive and thrive, all children require care and support from women and men. Care and support can be substantively improved by fostering gender equality, an important goal in its own right, and by reducing the gender-related barriers. Gender-related barriers include women's and girls' disproportionate lack of information, knowledge and technology, resources, and safety and mobility, as well as the gender division of labour and gender norms. For example, a mother's lack of mobility, due to prohibitive norms or lack of transportation, may impede birth registration, nutrition, and other child outcomes. The internalization of gender norms around masculine and feminine expectations and behaviours may influence women's and men's attitudes toward intimate partner violence and physical punishment of children as well as self-perceptions of well-being, including life satisfaction and expectations for the future.

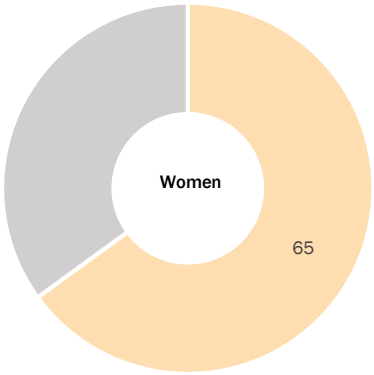
Access to Knowledge, Information & Technology

Literacy



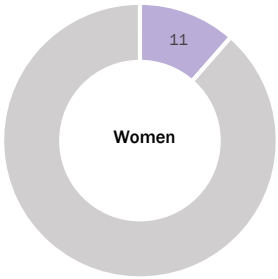
Percentage of women age 15-49 who are literate, by sex

Media Access



Percentage of women age 15-49 who read a newspaper, listen to the radio, or watch television at least once a week

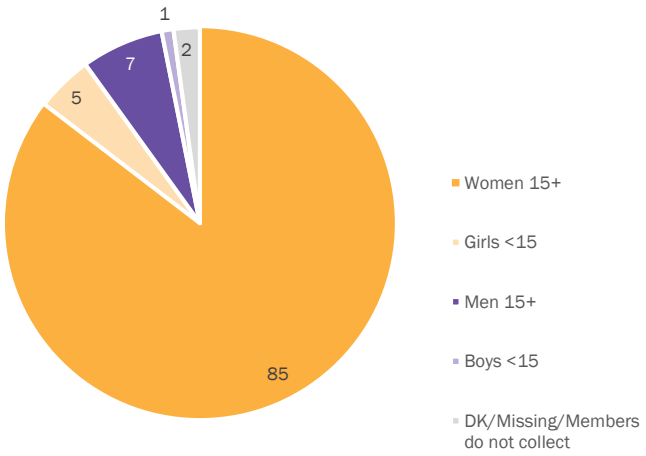
Internet Use: SDG17.8.1



Percentage of women age 15-49 using the internet at least once a week in the past 3 months, by sex

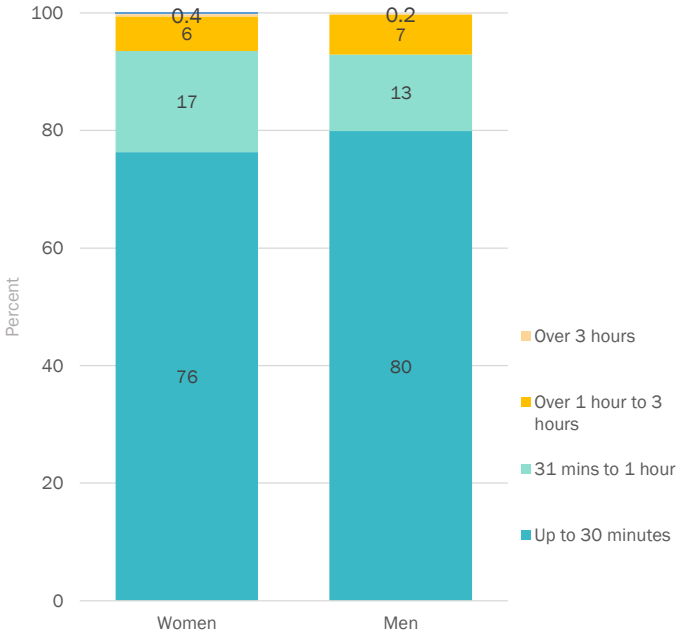
Time on Household Chores: Water Collection

Who collects water?



Percent distribution of household members without drinking water on premises by person usually collecting drinking water used in the household

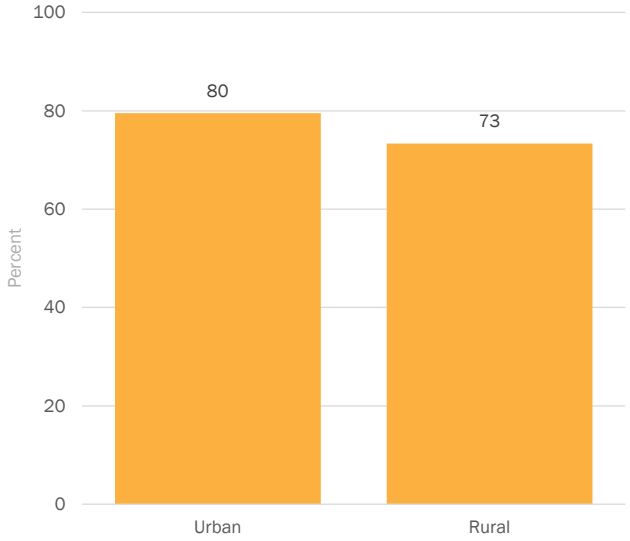
Time spent on water collection



Percent distribution of average amount of time spent collecting water per day by sex of person primarily responsible for water collection in households without drinking water on premises

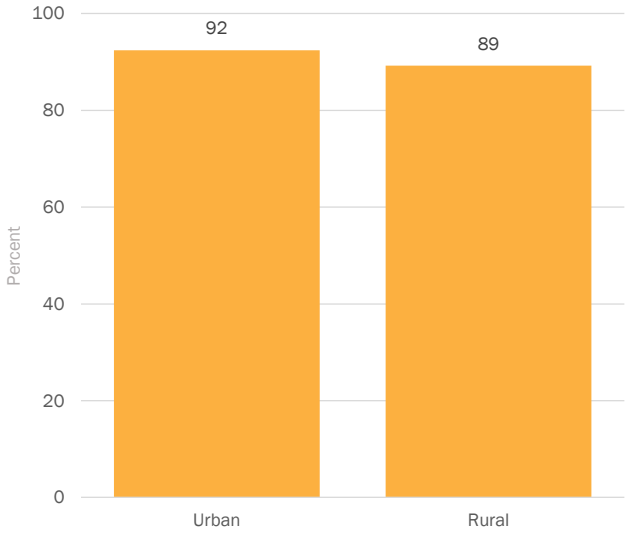
Safety & Security

Feeling safe while walking alone, SDG 16.1.4 sex disaggregate



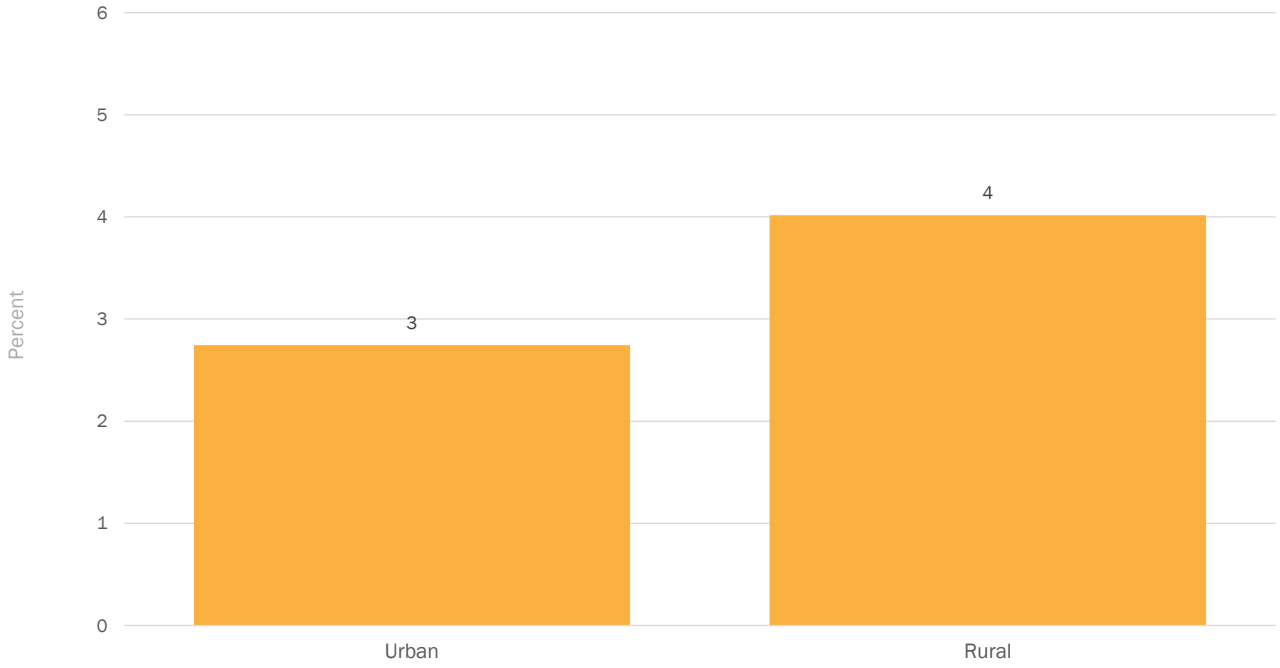
Percentage of women (age 15-49) who feel safe walking alone in their neighbourhood after dark, by area

Feeling safety while being at home alone



Percentage of women (age 15-49) who feel safe being home alone after dark, by area

Discrimination & harassment

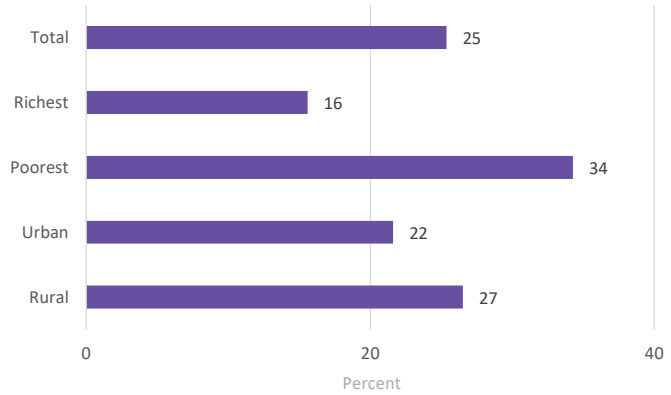


Percentage of women age 15-49 who in the last 12 months have personally felt discriminated or harassed based on their gender, by area

Gender Equality in Adulthood

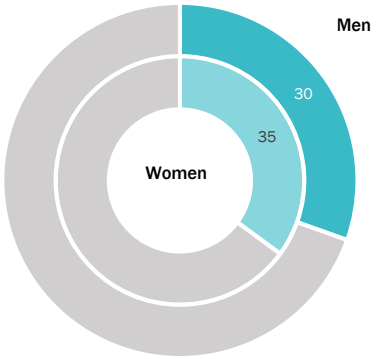
Feminine and masculine attitudes & expectations

Attitudes toward domestic violence among women



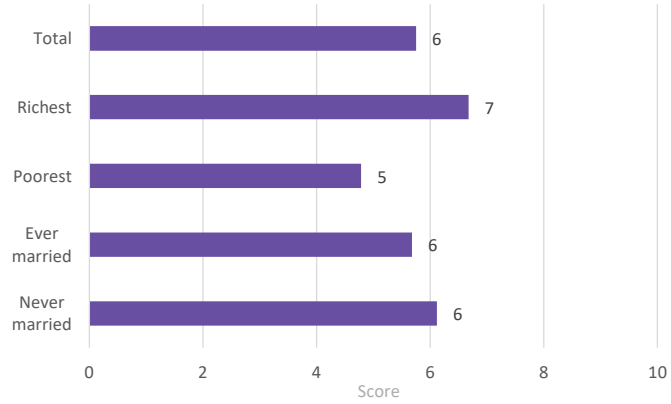
Percentage of women age 15-49 who justify wife beating for any of the following reasons: she goes out without telling him; she neglects the children; she argues with him; she refuses sex with him; she burns the food, by sex, wealth quintile and area

Attitudes toward physical punishment



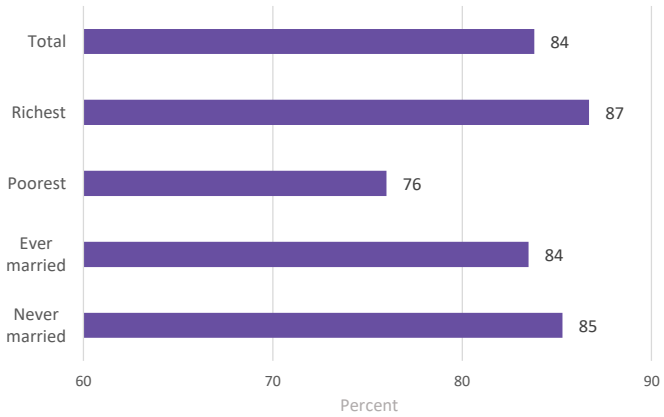
Percentage of caretakers who believe that physical punishment is needed to bring up, raise, or educate a child properly, by sex of caretaker

Life satisfaction



Among women age 15-49, average life satisfaction score on a scale of 0 to 10, by sex, wealth quintile and marital status. Higher scores indicate higher satisfaction levels.

Perceptions of a better life



Percentage of women age 15-49 who expect that their lives will get better in one year, by sex, wealth quintile and marital status

Key Messages

- In Bangladesh, 68% of married women 15-49 years are literate, and 64% access media at least once a week. However, women in Bangladesh have minimal access to the internet; only 11% of married women used the internet at least once a week.
- Water collection remains a very gendered chore in Bangladesh. Eighty-five percent of women age 15 years or older usually collect water for use by the household; a further 5% of households often send a female child under the age of 15 years to collect water.
- Most married women age 15-49 years feel safe walking alone in their neighborhood after dark, but urban women (80%) feel safer than rural women (73%). The majority of women feel safe while being at home alone (92% in urban areas and 89% in rural areas).
- One in four married women in Bangladesh see it justified for a husband to beat his wife as punishment for doing something wrong (going out, neglecting children, burning food, refusing sex, arguing). These attitudes are even more prevalent in rural areas (27%) and amongst poor women (34%). These data indicate a great need for awareness-raising in communities in Bangladesh regarding how women understand their rights to live in a safe environment free from violence and their right to make decisions for themselves.
- Data related to life satisfaction amongst women in Bangladesh indicate worrying results. On average, women from the poorest households reported five on a scale of 1-10 regarding life satisfaction. Importantly, many women (84%) expect that life will get better in the next year (although only 76% of poor women expected a better life in the next year). These data might indicate that many women in Bangladesh are currently unhappy, even if they still hope for a better future. More work needs to done to better understand mental and emotional wellness amongst women and men in Bangladesh.

The Bangladesh Multiple Indicator Cluster Survey (MICS) was carried out in 2019 by the Bangladesh Bureau of Statistics as part of the global MICS programme. Technical and financial support was also provided by the United Nations Children's Fund (UNICEF).

The objective of this snapshot is to disseminate selected findings from the Bangladesh MICS 2019 related to Gender Equality. Data from this snapshot can be found in table CS.3, TC.8.1, TC.10.1, TC.11.1, PR.1.1,, PR.2.1,, LN.1.2, LN.2.3, LN.2.4, LN.2.6, LN.2.7, TM.3.1, TM.3.2, TM.3.3, TM3.4, TM.2.3, TM.11.1, SR.10.1, SR4.1, SR.4.3, SR.6.1, PR.8.1, 5.1, PR.2.2, PR.5.1, PR.5.3, EQ.3.1, PR.7.1, EQ.5.1, SR.9.3., EQ.2.1 WS.4.1, WS.4.2, WS 1.3 and WS 1.4..

Further statistical snapshots and the Summary Findings Report for this and other surveys are available on mics.unicef.org/surveys.